modern human activity. This alarming phenomenon first attracted public attention in 1999, when American environmental scientist Malcolm McCallum published his findings about the dramatic increase in deformities in frogs. He went on to produce landmark studies on amphibian decline and extinction.

The causes of the problem are wide-ranging, and include habitat destruction and pollution, as well as competition from nonnative species. But one of the most devastating causes is undoubtedly disease, with two particularly lethal culprits.

Chytrid and ranavirus

Chytridiomycosis is a disease caused by the chytrid fungus, and it has ravaged populations of frogs and toads in particular. The fungus affects amphibians' skin, such that they are not able to breathe, hydrate, or regulate their temperature. The exact origin of the fungus is not known, but the global trade in live amphibians for various uses, be it pets, food, fishing bait, or research, has been a major factor in its spread.

Ranaviruses evolved from a fish virus. They infect amphibians and reptiles, and have caused mass mortality in frogs since the 1980s. The common midwife toad ranavirus causes bleeding, skin sores, lethargy, and emaciation. It is notably virulent as it has the ability to "jump" from one species to another.